



Responsibility for Justice

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CHAPTER

Three Three Guilt versus Responsibility: A Reading and Partial Critique of Hannah Arendt

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Abstract

This chapter explicates the distinction between guilt and responsibility as it appears in Hannah Arendt's essays, "Organized Guilt and Universal Responsibility" and "Collective Responsibility." It then supplements this interpretation with a reading of her book *Eichmann in Jerusalem*, specifically from the point of view of the distinction between guilt and responsibility. It argues that the detailed analysis that Arendt makes of the actions of many individuals and groups during the time of the Nazi mass murder of Jews belies the simplicity of that idea. Out of a reading of *Eichmann*, the chapter distinguishes four ways that agents related to these state-perpetrated crimes. Out of these distinctions a notion of political responsibility is derived as a duty for individuals to take public stands about actions and events that affect broad masses of people, and to try to organize collective action to prevent massive harm or foster institutional change for the better. The distinction between responsibility in this sense, and concepts associated with guilt, blame, and fault is important for political theory and practice.

Keywords: [guilt](#), [responsibility](#), [social injustice](#), [political theory](#), [Hannah Arendt](#), [Nazi](#), [Eichmann in Jerusalem](#), [political responsibility](#), [blame](#), [fault](#)

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The motivating question for this study is: how shall moral agents think about our responsibility in relation to structural social injustice? Hannah Arendt would not have been very sympathetic to such a question. She criticized the theoretical point of view that elevates the social, as this question does, in a political concern for economic exploitation, need deprivation, and the forms of domination that tend to accompany each. Though my ultimate purpose is thus at odds with some of Arendt's deepest convictions, I find in some of her writing

ideas that help me take some steps toward answering this question. In two short essays, “Organized Guilt and Universal Responsibility”¹ and “Collective Responsibility,”² Arendt distinguishes between guilt and responsibility in a way that suggests a direction for an answer to my question. This path cannot be charted, however, without clearing up some confusing items in Arendt’s discussion, and without criticizing some of her formulations.

Thus in this chapter I will explicate the distinction between guilt and responsibility as it appears in these texts. Then I will supplement this interpretation with a reading of Arendt’s book *Eichmann in Jerusalem*,³ specifically from the point of view of this distinction between guilt and responsibility. In some passages of that book, as in the essay “Collective Responsibility,” Arendt says that a specific form of responsibility she calls political responsibility derives simply from common membership in a nation and ↳ having to accept responsibility for wrongs done in its name. I will argue, however, that the detailed analysis that Arendt makes of the actions of many individuals and groups during the time of the Nazi mass murder of Jews belies the simplicity of that idea. Out of a reading of *Eichmann*, I will show, we can distinguish four ways that agents related to these state-perpetrated crimes. Out of these distinctions I derive a notion of political responsibility as a duty for individuals to take public stands about actions and events that affect broad masses of people, and to try to organize collective action to prevent massive harm or foster institutional change for the better. The distinction between responsibility in this sense, and concepts associated with guilt, blame, and fault, I suggest, is important for political theory and practice.

I

In “Collective Responsibility,” first presented as a comment on an essay by Joel Feinberg at a meeting of the American Philosophical Association in 1968, Arendt insists that moral and legal concepts such as guilt and blame should not be applied to entire groups or collectives. The paradigm case for her was Nazi Germany, about which she had debates with Karl Jaspers, among others, concerning the appropriateness of labeling the German people as a whole “guilty” for Nazi crimes. She insists that the concept of guilt (or innocence) applies strictly to individual *deeds*. Guilt loses its meaning if applied to a whole group or community related by association to a wrong. “Where all are guilty,” she says, “nobody is. Guilt, unlike responsibility, always singles out; it is strictly personal.”⁴ Twenty years earlier, in “Organized Guilt and University Responsibility,” Arendt expressed this thought in almost the same words: “Where all are guilty, nobody in the last analysis can be judged.”⁵

The point of locating guilt or leveling blame is precisely to single out: to say that this person, or these people, by virtue of what they have done, bear direct moral and often legal responsibility for a wrong or a crime, whereas others do not because their actions have not done the deeds. The practice of blaming or finding ↳ guilty requires singling out some from others, and applying some sanction against them or requiring compensation from them. The application of moral and legal guilt in this sense becomes meaningless if we extend it to a whole collective that is associated with the crime or wrong by virtue of being in the same society and passively allowing that crime or wrong. Guilt loses its practical meaning if we say that everyone in the society, or a large portion of people, is guilty of a crime or wrong committed in a society or in its name.

Arendt elaborates on this problem in *Eichmann*, using similar language. She puts into Eichmann’s mouth the possible excuse that he has acted as many others would have done if they had been in his place—believing in the Nazi Party, supporting its leaders, obeying directives that came down to him and thus responsibly doing his job. The suggestion is that those many other German citizens are just as guilty as Eichmann; he just had the bad luck to hold a position that entailed taking specific actions to organize the movement of trainloads of Jews to the death camps. So, on this hypothesis, he is no more guilty than they are. Arendt flatly rejects this excuse. On this theory, no one is singled out as guilty, and for Arendt that is the problem. There is a vast difference between people who might have done bad things, or who passively allow them, and the doers of the deeds: “No

matter through what accidents of exterior or interior circumstances you were pushed onto the road of becoming a criminal, there is an abyss between the actuality of what you did and the potentiality of what others might have done.”⁶

Guilt is objective and attributable whether or not the guilty party intends malevolence; it appears in the deeds, which must be proven to be those of the accused. An entire people, such as the German people, cannot be guilty. It is only metaphor to say that members of a political community *feel* guilty for the sins of their fathers or for those of mankind, for deeds they have not done. Expressing a feeling of guilt on behalf of an entire collective, not by virtue of deeds done but by virtue of one's membership in an association, is a sentimental gesture that obscures real political issues.⁷

p. 78 Arendt does not thereby deny that a collective and its members can be responsible in a different sense from being guilty. The point ↵ of the essay “Collective Responsibility” is precisely to distinguish guilt from what she there calls political responsibility. A collective can be responsible in political terms, rather than moral or legal terms. There are, Arendt says, two conditions for such collective responsibility: (1) I am responsible for what I have not done, and (2) **the reason for my responsibility is my membership in a group which no voluntary action of mine can dissolve**. The only example of such a collective that Arendt has in mind is a nation or political community. By virtue of the fact that I am a member of a political community, I am responsible for its actions or the things done by specific agents in the name of the nation or polity.⁸

This distinction between the moral and legal, on the one hand, and the political, on the other, is crucial for Arendt: “In the center of moral considerations of human conduct stands the self; in the center of political considerations of conduct stands the world.”⁹ Individuals can be blamed or found guilty only on the basis of what they have done; the moral and legal concern the self in that personal sense. Political responsibility, on the other hand, concerns how things stand in the world. Whatever the cause of sufferings, they are our responsibility to notice and address. Or, the sins of our fathers have continuing effect, and inasmuch as we belong to a political community continuous with theirs, we have responsibility for them.

p. 79 “Organized Guilt and Universal Responsibility,” first published in 1945, makes a similar distinction, phrased as a somewhat confusing paradox. Almost no member of German society escapes either guilt or responsibility for Nazi crimes, because the Nazis converted that society into one without “the neutral zone in which the daily life of human beings is ordinarily lived.”¹⁰ Societies are not usually organized in such a way that people find it difficult to avoid a relationship with massive historic crimes. As already discussed, however, this does not make all those in this relationship guilty. In relation to the Nazi crimes in particular, Arendt says, the number of those who are both responsible *and* guilty is relatively small. Many share responsibility without being guilty. No specific actions they performed directly contributed to the project of killing the Jews. Instead, they were supporters of ↵ the regime. Among these are those who “continued to be sympathetic to Hitler as long as it was possible, who aided his rise to power, and who applauded him in Germany and in other European countries.”¹¹ On the other hand, some people are guilty, she says, “without being in the least responsible.”¹² What can that mean? These persons certainly are responsible in the sense that they performed acts that furthered the criminal goals of the Nazis and were intended to further those goals. Why does Arendt say, then, that they are not “in the least responsible”? I think here she is using “responsible” in another sense, in the sense of acting with a morally appropriate sense of right and wrong. Arendt believes that such a sense all but disappeared from Nazi Germany, which is no excuse, however, for the criminal actions. Another possible interpretation for how those guilty of crimes by virtue of their actions could be “not responsible” is that they believe they have no alternative but to do what they do. They will lose their jobs, or endanger their families, if they refuse to act as directed or encouraged. In *Eichmann* Arendt shows that for many people at least, the claim is incorrect, and thus for the most part does not mitigate guilt.

I think that Arendt's effort to distinguish guilt from political responsibility is important and, with several refinements, can contribute to an answer to my starting question. I find highly unsatisfying, however, the

meaning she gives to political responsibility, especially in “Collective Responsibility.” It is a mystification to say that people bear responsibility simply because they are members of a political community, and not because of anything at all that they have done or not done. Shortly I will argue that the analysis she offers in *Eichmann* gives more specificity to an idea of political responsibility that challenges this interpretation. In a passage late in that book, however, Arendt articulates the same abstract and in my opinion implausible meaning to this notion of responsibility:

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Many people today would agree that there is no such thing as collective guilt or, for that matter, collective innocence, and that if there were, no one could ever be guilty or innocent. This, of course, is not to deny that there is such a thing as *political* ↳ responsibility, which, however, exists quite apart from what the individual member of the group has done and therefore can neither be judged in moral terms nor be brought before a criminal court.... It means hardly more, generally speaking, than that every generation, by virtue of being born into a historical continuum, is burdened by the sins of the fathers as it is blessed by the deeds of the ancestors.¹³

This cannot be all there is to political responsibility. It is plausible to say that “being born into a historical continuum” loads onto every person the imperative to take an attitude toward, and often to take specific actions in relation to, wrongs committed by one’s political ancestors. Leaving aside the difficulties in determining just who counts as the “fathers” for particular people, this cannot be all there is to political responsibility. Even Arendt herself enriches the idea elsewhere. When she discusses political responsibility for Nazi crimes, she mentions not only the next generation, but many contemporaries of the criminals. In “Collective Responsibility,” as well as in “Organized Guilt,” Arendt suggests that what it means to say that the contemporaries share responsibility is that they are members of the same political community in whose name the crimes have been committed. This sounds almost neo-Platonist: just by virtue of my participation in the entity that is the nation, I bear responsibility. Interpreted thusly, this idea of responsibility seems similar to but less honest than the notion of “metaphysical guilt” that Karl Jaspers proposed and Arendt rejected.¹⁴ I think there is a more plausible interpretation of a concept of shared political responsibility as distinct from guilt, however, at which Arendt only hints. “Organized Guilt” contains one such hint. As I quoted earlier, there Arendt says that among those responsible for but not guilty in relation to Nazi crimes are those who were sympathetic to Hitler, aided his rise to power, and applauded him. On this interpretation, political responsibility does entail *doing* things (and perhaps not doing things), but doing things that indirectly contribute to the enactment of crimes or wrongs. I propose now to perform a reading of *Eichmann* that draws out the meaning of being guilty and being ↳ politically responsible along these lines in a more thorough and specific manner.

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II

Eichmann in Jerusalem is a very rich text that can be read for many purposes. Here I have only one purpose, which will entail that I pass over many important insights and controversies suggested by the text. I find that Arendt’s account implicitly distinguishes four relationships that persons or agents have to the crime of the mass murder of Jews, whose meaning I will try to make explicit: (1) **those who are guilty of crimes**; (2) **those who are not guilty of crimes, but who bear responsibility because they participated in the society and provided the guilty agents with at least passive support that undergirded their power**; (3) **those who took action to distance themselves from the wrongs, either through efforts at preventing some of them or through forms of withdrawal**; and (4) **those who publicly opposed or resisted the wrongful actions**. As I read these distinctions, the first of these concerns moral and legal matters, the second political, the third moral again, and the fourth political. Added meaning for political responsibility emerges from my reading of this text, I suggest, **which challenges Arendt’s assertion in “Collective Responsibility” that we bear political responsibility simply by virtue of membership in a community and not according to more concrete social relationships and actions**.

1. Those guilty of the crime of mass murder.

Eichmann himself is guilty of horrible crimes. It is purely on account of what he *did* that he is guilty. And what did he do? He organized transportation for the deportation of Jews from all over Europe to death camps, located mostly in Eastern Europe. He also met with regional political officials, local Jewish leaders, and others to facilitate the delivery of Jews to the trains. The trial court in Jerusalem, and Arendt in her reportage, consider several issues that might mitigate Eichmann's criminal responsibility, and find them invalid.

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Doesn't the fact that Eichmann himself did not directly kill anyone diminish his guilt? From Arendt's account we learn not only that Eichmann himself did not kill, but also that he is horrified ↳ by the thought of killing. The fact that he himself did not kill does nothing to mitigate his guilt. Indeed, this vast crime was so organized that the direct killing was often done by victims themselves—other Jews who worked in the camps. The Jerusalem judges determined that in this crime “the extent to which any one of the many criminals was close to or remote from the actual killer of the victim means nothing, as far as the measure of responsibility is concerned. On the contrary, in general the degree of responsibility increases as we draw further away from the man who uses the fatal instrument with his own hands.”¹⁵

Why make this judgment, that guilt may *increase* with distance from the actual killing? Because many of those farther away in the causal chain made the decisions and gave the orders that drove the crimes, and their not having done so would have meant that hundreds of thousands of people might have lived. Eichmann's own decisions affected the movement of millions of people ultimately to their deaths, even though he himself was merely following directives.

Did Eichmann act under duress or without sufficient knowledge of the consequences of his acts? The court and Arendt consider this question and find that his actions were both voluntary and undertaken with knowledge of the consequences. He was neither forced nor insane. While Eichmann claims that his actions were not his own because he was under orders, Arendt makes the case that at every step he willingly accepted his role and at many points could have done otherwise. He **voluntarily** joined the party, applied for positions in the bureaucracy, and **did not resign or seek transfer** when his duties began to involve deportation and death.

Arendt does note that this case, in all its vast horror, challenges the legal idea that a crime must be accompanied by criminal *intent*, for Eichmann, as well as many others who participated in this crime, had no base motives. He was not a Nazi fanatic or a rabid anti-Semite. He had Jewish friends and admired the Zionist movement.

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Guilt in this case—and, Arendt suggests, in general—is not a matter of the perpetrator's subjective state; rather, **it is an objective consequence of his deeds**. It does not matter that Eichmann lacked malevolent intent. He is no monster, but an ordinary, normal ↳ person. Indeed, as Arendt tells it, this normality partly accounts for his ability to commit the crimes. Subjectively, on her account, Eichmann never experienced himself as doing anything wrong. **His focus was on himself, his ability to make a living and his status in relation to others. He was concerned with his career and his family.** He wanted to do his job well and to receive some recognition for it, especially from persons with higher social status than himself. He focused on the immediate bureaucratic tasks that had to be done to carry out orders from his superiors, more than on the final consequences of performing the tasks.

In “Organized Guilt” Arendt labels the likes of Eichmann “family men.”¹⁶ The “family man” is a man oriented primarily to private life and to ensuring the personal and economic security of those who depend on him for support. In his society, the family man is the epitome of virtue. He is concerned for his career, not so much because he is ambitious for himself, and certainly not because he is after fame or great power, but because he takes his primary duty to be to protect his family and himself from distress. People who fall into the family man type are people who do their jobs conscientiously and expect compensation for that, but otherwise mind their own business and try not to call attention to themselves. They and their families and friends keep to

themselves, and on the whole are indifferent to others outside their private circle. They expect the same from others. Arendt claims that “under the pressure of the chaotic economic conditions of our time” **the family man (and woman) would be prepared to do almost anything to ensure security and a comfortable life.** According to her account, Himmler in particular exploited this sense of chaos and desire for security:

It became clear that for the sake of his pension, his life insurance, the security of his wife and children, such a man was ready to sacrifice his beliefs, his honor, and his human dignity. It needed only the Satanic genius of Himmler to discover that after such degradation he was entirely prepared to do literally anything when the ante was raised and the bare existence of his family was threatened. The only condition he put was that he should be fully exempted from responsibility for his acts.¹⁷

p. 84 **The Nazi leaders waged wars of conquest and organized genocide by relying on this willingness of most Germans to do their jobs with indifference to their wider implications for the fate of others.** The aims of the leaders were extraordinary and diabolical. The character types on which they relied to enact these aims, however, belong to no particular nation or society: “The transformation of the family man from a responsible member of society, interested in all public affairs, to a ‘bourgeois,’ concerned only with his private existence and knowing no civic virtue, is an international modern phenomenon.”¹⁸ I need not dwell on the fact that the phenomenon remains in the twenty-first century.

Eichmann failed to experience himself as engaging in wrongdoing partly because no one around him criticized his actions and their ends. All the other normal family men around him acted as though the deportation and killing of the Jews was acceptable, a part of everyday life. He and they were able to consider the situation normal by means of massive *self-deception* facilitated in part by euphemistic terms that obscured the meaning of the acts to themselves. On Arendt’s account, Eichmann’s main character failing was not that he was cruel, malevolent, self-serving, or stupid, but that **he was thoughtless.** He failed to think about the meaning of his actions and their consequences, failed to understand the bureaucratic system from the point of view of its victims, failed to reflect upon the wider meaning of the social and political system in which he participated.

Eichmann is guilty of the crime of mass murder because he directly contributed to the machinery that produced it, because he valued doing his job in a murderous system, and because he could have done otherwise. The evidence that he could have done otherwise lies in the fact that some people, however few, did otherwise. But what of the vast numbers of normal Germans (and Romanians, etc.) who also acted as though everything was normal?

2. Those who are not guilty but bear responsibility.

p. 85 Because her focus is on Eichmann and his acts, Arendt says frustratingly little about the general question of “German guilt” which she debated with Jaspers after World War II, and which she noted that the youth of Germany were raising as she wrote this book in the early 1960s. Relying on the sketchy distinction she draws between guilt and political responsibility in the essays I have cited, I propose to fill in an aspect of the story by considering those who were not guilty of the crime of mass murder, but nevertheless bore responsibility.

Arendt raises the idea of collective guilt in *Eichmann* by reflecting on the German youth who say they “feel guilty” for Nazi crimes, even though they had no part in them. Many were not even born at the time, and others were too young to have done anything to contribute to them. Here again, she says, where all are guilty, none are. These youth are indulging in “cheap sentimentality” rather than the more difficult and dangerous work of politics. For among them there continue to live many persons who truly *are* guilty—persons who by virtue of their positions and actions at the time are guilty of crimes. Some of them turned in their neighbors, others worked in bureaucratic offices that contributed to the crimes, and others worked in factories that manufactured death gas. “There existed not a single organization or public institution in Germany, at least

during the war years, that did not become involved in criminal actions and transactions.”¹⁹ The murder of the Jews and other Nazi crimes required the mobilization of a whole society. That does not mean that everyone who worked in or was otherwise connected with institutions involved in criminal transactions is guilty of a crime; some people might be excepted because they were under duress or were understandably ignorant, or because their functions within the institutions were too indirectly related to the killing machines. But a great many people are individually guilty for this massive set of collective actions.

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Given the distinction that Arendt makes between guilt and responsibility, on the other hand, those in German society who were not a direct causal part of the killing machine by virtue of their actions are not guilty. But it would seem that they are responsible in the political sense. Arendt offers too sparse an account of what this might mean. In “Collective Responsibility” she says only that this responsibility derives from being a member of the political community. Just because they are Germans, the people who had no part in the crimes bear responsibility for what has been done in their name. I have argued that this is an implausible interpretation of the concept. I agree that there is a sense in which political responsibility is unavoidable, but it derives from something more specific and active than mere membership. I find aspects of Arendt’s story in *Eichmann* that support this alternative interpretation.

Consider the logic of the concept of guilt. The converse of the claim “If all are guilty none are” is: for some to be guilty, they need to be singled out from others who are not guilty. Although they are part of the same society, and may have been aware of some of the actions of those who are guilty but still did nothing to protest such actions, they cannot be justly accused, tried, and sentenced in any way. While many among the German people whose actions made them guilty were never accused, many more were not guilty. But it seems that for Arendt they bear responsibility in some sense, and she calls this a political responsibility.

What does political responsibility mean in this instance? Those on whom it falls are those who dwell within the social system that enables the crimes and supply that system with at least passive support. In this case, their passivity produces a political vacuum. The attitudes and behavior of the majority of people is so privatized that there exists little organized public space in which actors can appear to others with their judgments of events, let alone join in collective action to transform them.

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Arendt notes that during the Nazi period, and even, perhaps especially, during the war, the overwhelming majority of the German people believed in Hitler.²⁰ Together they enacted a mass self-deception, and supporting this mass self-deception became almost a moral requisite for survival. Mendacity, she says, became a part of the German national character. The people talked themselves into believing that they were not really in a war, or if they were that Germany was not an aggressor. Most of all, they believed that the very survival of Germany as a country and the Germans as a people was under threat and thus that the nation was justified in any actions it thought necessary in order to survive. Most of the people accepted the language of self-deception that authorities promulgated to hide the implications of evil acts from themselves and give them another moral meaning, such as calling murder “mercy death.” As Hitler came to power, they watched mutely as sites of political participation were shut down and people were imprisoned without charge or trial. They watched as Jews and others were discriminated against, their homes and property destroyed, their persons beaten, many with approval. Eventually they came to know of the disappearance of some of their neighbors, and many heard rumors of concentration camps that they chose to ignore. Many of them supported the idea that there is a moral difference between foreign Jews and German Jews, or between elite and educated Jews and working-class Jews. In the main, however, they tried not to think about any of these things—war, the actions of the state, what might be happening to their neighbors. Like Eichmann, they focused on their families and on doing their jobs, which, as luck would have it, did not implicate their actions directly in the killing machine.

This description is mine, not Arendt’s. She leaves too open what political responsibility means. Simple membership in the nation is too static a meaning. Being a member of a society usually has dynamic implications in terms of what a person believes and knows, and how he or she relates to the institutions of the

society and her or his fellow members. On the whole, the German people, like Eichmann, were thoughtless about the operation of those institutions and the actions of officials in them, and were indifferent to how others might be harmed by them. They evacuated any space of popular organization and critical accountability, leaving isolated and ineffectual the few of their fellow members who were inclined to think and criticize.

That even in Arendt's own estimation political responsibility is not coincidental with membership in the same nation-state can be illustrated by her own narrative. She devotes considerable attention to how states outside Germany related to German actions, and how the people of countries outside Germany related to the deportation of Jews. Some of these belong in the same category as the majority of the German people: while they did not do anything to contribute to the crimes, they also did nothing to protest them, and persisted in pretending that the events around them were normal and acceptable. The lack of response by a number of governments to a German letter asking them to recall Jewish nationals even when they were only nominally citizens may be an example of such passive indifference. The Vichy government of France cooperated with Germany's project of transporting Jews out of France as long as they were not French nationals, and presumably many French citizens turned their backs on these happenings.

p. 88 These all represent instances of a political responsibility not taken up. Because we dwell on the stage of history, and not simply in our houses, we cannot avoid the imperative to have a relationship with actions and events performed by institutions of our society, often in our name, and with our passive or active support. The imperative of political responsibility consists in watching these institutions, monitoring their effects to make sure that they are not grossly harmful, and maintaining organized public spaces where such watching and monitoring can occur and citizens can speak publicly and support one another in their efforts to prevent suffering. To the extent that we fail in this, we fail in our responsibility, even though we have committed no crime and should not be blamed. In the fourth category below I shall offer some of Arendt's examples of persons who take this sort of political responsibility. But first I will review another sort of relationship to criminal events.

3. Those who through their actions avoided guilt or attempted to prevent harm.

These people engaged in actions that were not only not blameworthy, but were praiseworthy from a moral point of view. While not the majority, there were many such people inside and outside Nazi Germany. Arendt gives the example of an artisan who gave up his independent existence and went to work in a factory rather than join the Nazi Party.²¹ Some academics gave up their positions rather than swear an oath to Hitler. Some did what they could to try to help Jews they knew, by hiding them or helping them leave the country. Arendt tells of two young men who were drafted into the SS and refused to sign the induction papers because they knew enough of the mission of this particular branch. These are a few stories, to which apparently thousands more can be added. These people, Arendt says, "practically speaking, did nothing." They are absolved from guilt; indeed, they are admirable. "Their ability to tell right from wrong had remained intact, and they never suffered a 'crisis of conscience'...They were neither heroes nor saints, and they remained completely silent."²²

p. 89 This last remark signals that their actions were not political, because they were not public. Many people tried to distance their actions from complicity with Nazi crimes or positively tried to aid those in danger, but they did so on their own, privately, without making much of an issue of it. Their actions are moral rather than political.

I read Arendt's tale of the intransigence of the Italian government and some of its people in response to the request of the Germans to turn over Jews in Italy and Italian occupied territory²³ in a similar way. In immediate contrast to the story of Denmark, which is one of political resistance, the story of the Italians is one of moral refusal. The Italians never offer public opposition to the Nazi plans. They humor the Nazis, saying they will do it tomorrow. But they do not comply with Germany's requests, and take measures to protect Jews in their jurisdictions, both Italian and foreign. They simply do not approve of the extermination program and will not

take part in it. While praiseworthy, and absolving them of guilt, this stance is not political in Arendt's sense, because it does not take the form of public protest.

4. Those who take political responsibility.

In "Collective Responsibility," Arendt says that political responsibility is strictly collective. One has this responsibility as part of a group. As I read *Eichmann*, however, this does not mean that political responsibility is exercised only by a state, or that individuals cannot take up their political responsibility by themselves or in small groups. Indeed, the exercise of responsibility is *political*, in Arendt's sense, only when it involves the active participation of citizens, rather than being merely the expression of the interests or wishes of state officials in their bureaucratic functions. To be political, action must be *public*, and aimed at the possibility or goal of *collective action* to respond to and intervene in historic events.

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Arendt finds very few instances of the taking of political responsibility in Nazi Germany. In her analysis, the relatively few who understood the evil of their government and opposed it were isolated and without the ability to speak. While pockets of acquaintances might have spoken of their opposition at dinner or church, they had "no plan or intention of revolt."²⁴ Some of those who participated in the conspiracy against Hitler did so not out of their ↵ repugnance to ongoing policies, but because they feared the shame of a Nazi defeat. There were a few intellectuals whose opposition to the Nazis was publicly known, such as Arendt's friend and teacher, Karl Jaspers. But this opposition had neither the intention nor the effect of motivating others to political action.

As I read *Eichmann*, Arendt does not think it appropriate to *blame* the German people, or that portion that still had a conscience, for not having taken political responsibility. She points out that by the start of the war, the Nazis had done a good job of repressing any public speech not directed by the party and had smashed organizations, such as unions, that might have served as springboards for public collective action. Opponents of the policies and events had good reason to think that efforts at organizing opposition and speaking publicly were futile. We know from Arendt's other writings, however, that she thinks that existing social circumstances never determine events, and that political action, especially when practically effective, is usually a *break* from an ongoing trajectory which people have come to accept as the way things are.²⁵

Arendt offers but one instance of an effort to take up political responsibility. The Scholls, two students in Munich, brother and sister, distributed leaflets in public that called Hitler a mass murderer.²⁶ Unlike praiseworthy moral acts, such as refusing to work in the SS or hiding Jews, this is a *political* act for two reasons: it is public, and it is aimed at inciting others to join the actors in public opposition to Hitler. Arendt also labels this gesture "desperate." She does not tell us what happened to the Scholls, but presumably they were jailed or worse, and their action did not precipitate an opposition movement.

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Arendt's stories of efficacious political action take place outside Germany, with the story of the Danes the most exemplary. Arendt introduces the story as a paradigm of collective political action: "One is tempted to recommend the story as required reading in political science for all students who wish to learn something about the enormous power potential inherent in non-violent action and in resistance to an opponent possessing vastly ↵ superior means of violence."²⁷ From the king on down, Danish officials announced publicly their opposition to the German policy of deporting Jews. When the Swedish government refused to let German troops pass through its country, Danish dockworkers went on strike and refused to service German ships. A vast number of participants in the country, including government officials, police, fishermen, and many other ordinary Danish citizens, cooperated in a tightly organized and successful project to locate nearly all the Jews in the country, whatever their national origin or current citizenship, get them to the docks, and transport them quietly in the night by boat to safety in Sweden. In the face of public opposition and organized resistance to Nazi policies, German officials stationed in Denmark changed their attitude, demurring from efforts to prevent the Danes' actions.

Arendt relates other instances of public opposition to the German policy of deportation and murder. Once the Vichy government understood that their own nationals, and not only refugees, were the intended targets, they refused to cooperate. In Holland students went on strike when Jewish professors were dismissed, and there was a wave of strikes in response to the first deportations to concentration camps. In Bulgaria the parliament spoke out against the concentration camps, and people came into the streets of Sofia to try to stop the transportation of the Jews.²⁸

The lesson of these instances of public opposition, as well as the Danish events, is that when concerted, and involving a large number of people, it is often effective: "The Nazis, it turned out, possessed neither the manpower nor the will power to remain 'tough' when they met determined opposition."²⁹

This ends my reading of *Eichmann in Jerusalem*, in light of the two essays I have cited. My purpose has been to unpack the suggestive but undertheorized distinction Arendt makes between guilt and responsibility, and, in particular, political responsibility. To summarize, guilt should be attributed to persons who commit crimes or wrongs, or directly contribute by their actions to crimes or wrongs. Being responsible, but not guilty, is a designation that belongs to persons whose active or passive support for governments, institutions, and practices enables culprits to commit crimes and wrongs. As I read it, this distinction is a matter not of degree, but of kind. Guilt can come in degrees. We might properly say that the person who plans the construction of a camp that detains prisoners without charge is more guilty of a crime against international law than those who supervise the guards are. But both are guilty. Responsibility, as Arendt puts it, devolves onto people who haven't committed the wrongs, but who are nevertheless connected to them. In this sense I have a political responsibility in relation to activities at Guantánamo Bay and similar extralegal detention camps.

In Arendt's discussion, political responsibility seems to be a concept just as backward-looking as guilt. Her primary case is the Nazi Holocaust, whose events are in the past. We want to know who bears responsibility for these events to which we look back, in the sense of who is guilty and who by their passive support and evacuation of a space of public criticism ceded to the guilty their power to do their deeds.

Even as Arendt narrates these past events in *Eichmann*, however, I see something essentially forward-looking about this idea of political responsibility. This responsibility falls on members of a society by virtue of the fact that they are aware moral agents who ought not to be indifferent to the fate of others and the danger that states and other organized institutions often pose to some people. This responsibility is largely unavoidable in the modern world, because we participate in and usually benefit from the operation of these institutions. The meaning of political responsibility is forward-looking. One *has* the responsibility always *now*, in relation to current events and in relation to their future consequences. We are in a condition of having such political responsibility, and the fact of having it implies an imperative to *take* political responsibility. If we see injustices or crimes being committed by the institutions of which we are a part, or believe that such crimes are being committed, then we have the responsibility to try to speak out against them with the intention of mobilizing others to oppose them, and to act together to transform the institutions to promote better ends. In this sense political responsibility is forward-looking; it means in the first stance taking up a responsibility to be political.

To be sure, there may be situations in which taking responsibility in this way is really not possible. Nazi Germany in 1941 is arguably such a situation. In most social situations where wrongs occur, moreover, most people say with reason that there is nothing they can do. As isolated individuals, they can do nothing to change institutions, powerful officials, or the interactions of states. Political responsibility is not about doing something by myself, however, but about exhorting others to join me in collective action. When this occurs, and it occurs relatively infrequently, movement participants are often the most surprised at the transformative power they turn out to have.

I began with the question: how shall moral agents think about our responsibility in relation to structural social injustice? An example of structural injustice is a situation in which there is a lack of availability of affordable

housing that forces numbers of people into indecent shelter or makes them vulnerable to homelessness. Structural injustice is not as horrible as systematically perpetrated genocide; I think of it as “ordinary” injustice. Such injustice must be of concern to us as moral and political agents, precisely because it is more everyday, and often conditions other criminal acts. I find the idea of political responsibility that I have interpreted and developed out of Arendt’s texts particularly useful for giving an account of responsibility in relation to structural injustice. ↴

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Notes

1. Hannah Arendt, “Organized Guilt and Universal Responsibility,” in *Essays in Understanding, 1930–1954*, ed. Jerome Kohn (New York: Harcourt-Brace, 1994), 121–132.
2. Hannah Arendt, “Collective Responsibility,” in *Amor Mundi: Explorations in the Faith and Thought of Hannah Arendt*, ed. James W. Bernauer (Boston: M. Nijhoff, 1987), 43–50.
3. Hannah Arendt, *Eichmann in Jerusalem_ A Report on the Banality of Evil* (New York: Viking Press, 1963).
4. Arendt, “Collective Responsibility,” 43.
5. Arendt, “Organized Guilt,” 126.
6. Arendt, *Eichmann*, 278.
7. Arendt, “Collective Responsibility,” 43; *Eichmann*, 251.
8. Arendt, “Collective Responsibility,” 45.
9. Arendt, “Collective Responsibility,” 47.
10. Arendt, “Organized Guilt,” 124.
11. Arendt, “Organized Guilt,” 125.
12. Arendt, “Organized Guilt,” 125.
13. Arendt, *Eichmann*, 297–298.
14. Karl Jaspers, *The Question of German Guilt*, trans. E. B. Ashton [pseudo.] (New York: Capricorn Books, 1961).
15. Arendt, *Eichmann*, 247.
16. Arendt, “Organized Guilt,” 128–129.
17. Arendt, “Organized Guilt,” 128–129.
18. Arendt, “Organized Guilt,” 129.
19. Arendt, *Eichmann*, 159.
20. Arendt, *Eichmann*, 98–99.
21. Arendt, *Eichmann*, 104.
22. Arendt, *Eichmann*, 104.
23. Arendt, *Eichmann*, 176–180.
24. Arendt, *Eichmann*, 99–100.
25. See, for example, Hannah Arendt, *The Human Condition* (Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1958), 176–178.
26. Arendt, *Eichmann*, 104.
27. Arendt, *Eichmann*, 171.
28. Arendt, *Eichmann*, 187.
29. Arendt, *Eichmann*, 165.